METHODOLOGY

HOW THE UNIVERSITIES WERE RANKED

With 655 general, 79 medical, 192 technical and 27 law universities to choose from, the India Today Group's annual ranking of Best Universities has a special place in the country's academic calendar. It not only makes critical career decision easier for aspirants based on rich information and data, but also provides an overview of the state of university education to other stakeholders—recruiters, parents, alumni, policy makers and people at large.

INDIA TODAY's knowledge partner Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), a reputed research agency, followed a rigorous methodology while doing this survey between March-July 2025. During objective ranking, MDRA has carefully attuned 125+ attributes to provide the most comprehensive and balanced comparison of universities. These performance indicators were clubbed into five broad parameters—'Reputation & Governance', 'Academic & Research Excellence', 'Infrastructure & Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. The ranking was done based on the latest data provided by the universities.

A list of 775-plus qualifying universities fulfilling the criteria was prepared. Postgraduate courses under four streams—general, medical, technical and law—were considered for evaluation. Only universities offering full-time, in-classroom courses and having churned out minimum three pass-out batches by the end of 2024 qualified for ranking.

Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for respective categories of universities. Indicators were meticulously determined, and their relative weights were finalised.

A comprehensive objective questionnaire was sent to qualifying universities and also uploaded on the MDRA website. As many as 176 universities provided their data along with voluminous supporting documents within the stipulated deadline.

After receipt of the objective data from universities, a detailed scrutiny of the supporting documents was done. Data was verified by every possible means. An objective score was given to each university under the five indicators. While computing objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone is not used and hence data were normalised.

A perceptual survey was carried out among well-informed 302 respondents—28 chancellors/ vice-chancellors, 72 directors/ deans/ registrars, 202 senior faculty (professors and head of the departments)—across more than 20 cities divided into four zones.

↘ North – Delhi-NCR, Lucknow, Jaipur, Chandigarh
↘ West – Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad and Indore
↘ South – Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Coimbatore
↘ East – Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati and Patna

National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective field of experience and were given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage, respectively. They also rated the universities on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five key parameters. The total scores arrived from the objective and perception survey were added in the ratio of 50:50 to get the total combined score.

MOST IMPROVED UNIVERSITIES

A new category called 'Most Improved Universities' has been added to the INDIA TODAY-MDRA Best Universities Survey 2025. It highlights universities that have made the most progress over the past five years. The ranking is based on how much a university's position has improved in the annual rankings from 2020 to 2025, measured by percentage rise in rank. The university with the biggest jump is ranked first, followed by others in order of their improvement.

The MDRA core team led by Abhishek Agrawal (Executive Director) included Abnish Jha (Project Director), Vaibhav Gupta (Deputy Research Manager), Kamaldeep Kaur (Assistant Research Executive), Robin Singh (Assistant Research Executive) and Manveer Singh (Assistant Manager EDP). ■